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# Sam Most

*Sam Most was born in Atlantic City on December 16, 1930. He was playing professionally by the age of 18, spending time in the sax sections of bands led by Tommy Dorsey, Boyd Raeburn and Don Redman. While equally accomplished on tenor sax and clarinet, it is Sam's flute playing that is recognized as a major contribution to jazz. Since the early 1950s, Sam has been pioneering on the flute, developing new techniques and influencing future jazz artists. He has traveled extensively and performed with a long list of fellow jazz greats, including Buddy Rich, Henry Mancini, Gerry Mulligan and Art Blakey. Sam currently performs in the Los Angeles area and can occasionally be found on the bandstand with his brother, clarinetist Abe Most.*

*Sam was interviewed in Los Angeles on February 15, 1999, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.*

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Los Angeles filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. I've been looking forward to talking with Sam Most, saxophonist, flautist and clarinetist. You've been around for a long time, like on the forefront of a number of things in jazz. So welcome.

SM: Yeah, it's a pleasure.

MR: You know you and your brother, your family went back and forth between New York and Atlantic City.

SM: That's right. Well I was born in Atlantic City, but there's some story, I don't know if my brother told you but someone put a little letter in the box, "We'd like to kidnap one of your twins." And I'm a twin. I have a twin sister. They said if you don't hand over a certain amount of money, ten thousand or whatever it was at the time. And so —

MR: Are you making this up?

SM: No I'm not making this up.

MR: This is wild.

SM: So they were in Atlantic City my folks, so they couldn't find out who did it. I guess they had the FBI out. And they got scared and they said let's move out of here, you know someone put a threat in. I don't know if it was a family member or whether outside the family, but that's what — my father had a little grocery business or something. So we moved to New York when I was four, so I really consider myself a New Yorker. So I was living there until about 1960, and I was born in 1930.

MR: Wow, I hadn't heard that story before.

SM: Yeah, he probably didn't mention that, but that's one of the things, when you mentioned Atlantic City, I remember there was a piano in Atlantic City. I think we had an upstairs and a downstairs.

MR: So that's your memory of really your birthplace.

SM: Yeah.

MR: You said your father was a grocer? He had a grocery store?

SM: He had a candy store or something, yeah. And I think he did some, well during the depression I hear he did some moonshining.

MR: Cool. A little family history there.

SM: A little family history.

MR: I mean how much candy can you actually sell?

SM: Yeah, that's true.

MR: Was he or your mother musical?

SM: Actually my father was kind of, he used to sing in the temple and things like that, like almost like a cantor, but not officially a cantor. And my mother had a good ear. But they didn't have any music — they weren't in any musical things.

MR: So I wonder where those musical genes came from in you and your brother?

SM: We don't know.

MR: Very interesting.

SM: We're not really sure except of course I idolized my brother when I was growing up you know, he was already on the road with Les Brown or Tommy Dorsey and he's ten or eleven years older, so as I say I idolized him when I was growing up because he was playing these great clarinet solos and everything.

MR: That's good. A lot of times siblings don't exactly get along too well.

SM: Right. No I got his old metal clarinet then I got his other clarinet you know, the Selmer.

MR: Hand-me-down instruments.

SM: Yeah.

MR: Yeah there you go. Did you take up the clarinet or the saxophone first, or was it the flute?

SM: I took up, I guess I was eleven I believe when I had a few clarinet lessons. They used to have a teacher on 48th Street, Louis Arfine. And so I started the clarinet and then came the alto I believe and then you have to play the flute to get into the bands so I started the flute, and it seemed not too many people were playing jazz on the flute, and that was around the nineteen fifty something area.

MR: You're right. There seems to be a little bit of controversy, but you hear different stories of who actually was the first jazz flute player. Your name always comes up.

SM: Yeah my name seems to come up. I understand there could have been some others that I don't know their playing or I don't know who started first, but Waymon Carver and some other people.

MR: I think it's more — they maybe just used it incidentally. So who was the first person to really—

SM: It seems like I was one of the first ones that used it kind of in the bebop way, and mostly from absorbing some of the Charlie Parker and the bebop saxophonists, and just transferring it to the flute.

MR: Did you get into swing from the radio or just because your brother was out there doing it?

SM: More from the radio and then of course his was more of a Swing Era, and I grew up with I guess 15 or so, in 1945 or before, I used to hear Lester Young and Charlie Parker and things, Lennie Tristano, and I grew up more with that new influence. And then of course after it came the Coltrane, after me. So yeah, I grew up with that. So I kind of went hey this is interesting, and I kind of was interested in that.

MR: Did you ever get with your brother and say hey, check out this bop, come on, get with it.

SM: I think I mentioned some things like that. I think he was more, you know you get stuck in your ways a little bit. So I think he liked it but I think it was more like the swing's the thing. If it don't swing, you know, with the recognizable thing, the other thing was a little far out, just like certain things are far out for me. I mean I'm interested like these "Stellar Explorations," John Coltrane you know. But I mean it's interesting but I don't know if I'd want to go there, or could go there.

MR: Yeah. That's a ways out there.

SM: Yeah, that's what I meant. So I mean it seems like it's just a different twist on the language. And if you're not in that generation, not everybody picks up the new language.

MR: That's a good way to put it.

SM: That's the way I kind of—

MR: Did music become your career right away or did you do other things before music?

SM: It seems like it became my career — I guess there were opportunities, whatever it was, when I was about 17. I had a little bebop band in the Catskill mountains, New York, and we were playing [scats] that type thing. So I grew up with that and I think just when I got out of high school I think just for a very short period, six months, I worked for Blue Cross Plan. It was just papers. But then after that it was all music.

MR: Were you playing — when you said you were in the Catskills you said — was it a resort thing?

SM: Yeah. They had all these hotels in the Catskills, and you know at night you played some of the shows, different people, comedians and singers and different things. And you also

could play like some jazz or solo. And so about ten years in the summers I used to go away and I think I once had a piano gig with a vocal group, I played piano. But other times I'd play the flute and saxophone.

MR: Good training.

SM: Yeah. And I'll probably skip around here and there sort of on what I was talking about.

MR: When was the first opportunity to record for you?

SM: Let me see when was the first. I had a friend, his name was Arnold Rosen and he was kind of like a pusher you know. He pushed me because he thought I was the next Benny Goodman you know, at the time. And so I think he might have been influential. I reckon the first one had Dick Hyman on piano. This is, I'm not sure, in 1952 or whatever it was, I did a little 45 with Dick Hyman and Clyde Lombardi, and Jackie Moffett I think. This was the personnel. That was a 45. That's when 45s were around. And if I'm not mistaken I could have been on Prestige Records. But what did you ask me again?

MR: Was this "Undercurrent Blues?"

SM: That's the one I'm talking about, yeah. Here and there I meet somebody that says "you know I have a copy of that 'Undercurrent Blues.'" But I don't know where my copy is.

MR: If I can find one I'll send it to you. They're nice to have, don't you think?

SM: Sure.

MR: Was it your own tune?

SM: I believe so. I don't remember it. It was a while back there.

MR: And what was the instrument?

SM: I was playing flute. Yeah, I think maybe the whole record was a flute thing. And then shortly after that, well I think it was in 1954, I'm talking about this guy that was kind of pushing my career, we got into the studio and I don't know exactly how it is, maybe he put up the money or I put up the money, we got a thing called "Sam Most Plus Two." I don't know if you're familiar with that. That was a thing that Charlie Mingus put out on Debut Records. Now what happened was I had Louie Bellson on drums, Percy Heath and who else, Urbie Green and Bob Dorough and who else did we have there, I might be missing somebody, Doug Metamie on trumpet and Dave Schildkraut, Davie Schildkraut.

MR: Oh, the alto player?

SM: Yeah. I don't think he's around anymore. So anyhow, so my friend brought it to Charlie Mingus, he liked it and he put it out. And so that started something. I think that was before I had, then I don't remember what happened but I got four albums out on Bethlehem. I don't know if you know anything about those?

MR: No, sorry.

SM: I had one big band album, with a lot of the New York people. One of the things I had was do you remember a fellow Teddy Cohen? Vibe player? In fact I worked up in Syracuse with him with Pepper Adams, you know he had a group up there. Well anyhow he wrote, Hall Overton, who wrote the thing for Monk. I was studying with him for a little while, and he was too busy because I wanted him to write some music, so he asked Teddy Charles, Teddy Cohen, he changed his name, to write this string quartet album. So I had a string quartet album at that time I guess in the 50s, and I had Jimmy Raney and Art Farmer's brother, and some of the Metropolitan Opera string people. It was really good and very modern. This guy I guess studied with Hall and had some things that sounded like Bartok at the time, with the strings and I played clarinet and flute on it. And I was going to mention a few things about it — oh yeah, and anyhow a half hour before the date, a drummer said, "I'm sending someone else down because I can't make it but he's good," and guess who it was?

MR: Who was it?

SM: Roy Haynes.

MR: Oh. I guess he's pretty good.

SM: So he called me up a half hour before the date. And he sent in one of Lennie Tristano's guys, Harold Barnowski, but I just wanted Roy. That might have made the whole difference with the thing. And anyhow, that's the story with that thing. So I had one big band, then a quartet album with Bob Dorough and some other people and I got about four or five albums on Bethlehem, some arranged things at the time.

MR: Meanwhile, while you're doing this recording, what kind of — are you living in New York City?

SM: Living in New York.

MR: And what kind of work was paying your rent?

SM: Oh, let's see.

MR: I mean was there enough jazz gigs around for you to live on it?

SM: Well not primarily jazz, I guess they were casuals, you know like the bar mitzvahs, the weddings, some of those things. I did have a small group, I don't know what year it was, several groups at a club called The Composer, I don't know if you ever heard of that room. And I once had Teddy Kotick on bass and guess who the intermission pianist was?

MR: Oh let's see. Erroll Garner?

SM: Close. Bill Evans.

MR: Oh gee, no kidding.

SM: He was the intermission pianist and I says who's this guy, wow, he really plays you know. I saw him later. I just remember him, Bill Evans was the intermission pianist at

this place. But I had a quartet and I was playing clarinet and tenor I guess, and probably a little flute but I remember clarinet and tenor. And we had a six night a week gig. I don't remember years too well.

MR: Did you have to go down to the union and like hang out waiting for gigs or were those days gone?

SM: Yeah that was the days when you went down to the union and said do you have Saturday? You know, I mean anything happening on Saturday? Or you'd see people that says hey you working Saturday? We got a gig for you. You know, this wedding, this bar mitzvah, this party. So there was a little coming in that way. I was doing some concerts around New York too. I haven't thought about this for a long time, but I did some, this is just fragments of association. I did one concert with, I had a small group at Town Hall, I think I had Charlie Persip and I forgot who else. Well I don't remember too well. But another concert in Connecticut, and who was sitting in the audience right in front of us but Dizzy Gillespie and Sonny Stitt so I was a little nervous doing those jazz concerts. So I got to do some of those and the recordings and jamming. I remember going to Harlem and I guess every Saturday I'd jam with a piano player and bass player. We'd go through the twelve keys on "Cherokee."

MR: Oh, no kidding.

SM: Yeah.

MR: It's like a little testing ground, ey?

SM: Yes, we'd play "Cherokee" in twelve keys, and other tunes in twelve keys, like all working out together. That was good you know. And that was the days when you could get to go to Harlem and it was like everybody's welcome.

MR: So the racial scene between musicians was cool?

SM: Yeah. Really cool. There wasn't too much static like we can't come to our part of town or else it's a little uncool you know. There was more movement going on.

MR: Did it change while you were still in New York?

SM: No I think it changed at the end of when I was in New York. It just seemed to be a little bit more, what do you call it, the opposite thing, like where before everybody kind of blended together and you could work together. Now they tended toward all-black and then all-white. Not everybody.

MR: You moved to Los Angeles when?

SM: Somewhere in the early 60s.

MR: While the Civil Rights movement was getting going, and I guess there was a certain amount of black power type things?

SM: Yeah, those things were happening, yeah, a little bit. I remember being down at the Village Vanguard and thinking, that was me, I mean knew me, John Coltrane, and I was to him about reeds backstage and he was trying different reeds, this doesn't work, that doesn't work, and I asked Jimmy Garrison, his bass player, "What are you guys doing with this new thing with McCoy Tyner and everything." And all he would tell me is "We're just playing. I mean we're just doing things we do." I mean there wasn't any secret that he could tell me like well we're extending this chord or playing modal. He wouldn't tell me anything other than we're just doing our thing. I mean so I couldn't get any information because I wanted to know what is it that they're doing that's so, you know, it was getting further out there and interesting. But I couldn't really pick up on what they were thinking about when they were doing this.

MR: Either he didn't want to give away any secrets, or maybe they were just doing that.

SM: Yeah, they were just doing that without thinking like well we're doing this and that's why we're —

MR: Yeah, that's why it sounds like it does.

SM: Yeah. So I think no one, I mean whoever was, I think I mentioned Jimmy Garrison, I'm not sure who else I spoke to.

MR: Did Coltrane's music appeal to you at that time?

SM: Something very interesting about it, yeah. They take these long solos. I think I heard a half hour or forty-five minute solo at Birdland, you know it just goes on and on and on and on. I says I couldn't figure out exactly, it was pretty intense stuff. I remember another intense thing when I was in New York. I went down to hear an Albert Ayler concert.

MR: Oh boy.

SM: And I stayed there for three hours and I almost threw up because it seemed like they were just [scats] doing all these out things. I says what the heck are they talking about? What does this mean?

MR: Yeah.

SM: But I had to go down and hear it for myself, you know I was interested in some of the records of Albert Ayler and this type of stuff.

MR: And you stayed for three hours, huh?

SM: I stayed for three hours because they had several people do whole — it sounded like they would do — I mean all sorts of odd-like, just like, well it sounded angry. But some of it was very interesting, then some of it perhaps not.

MR: That's very diplomatic of you. Perhaps not. You even did, to backtrack just a touch, you did some gigs with Tommy Dorsey and a few of the big bands?

SM: Oh yeah. I went on the road for about eight months with Shep Fields, I was playing alto and clarinet. And then I guess, who was on that band, Red Mitchell's brother was playing bass on that band, but after I got off that, that was commercial. I guess my brother had been playing with Tommy Dorsey and he probably said hey my kid brother's playing clarinet, maybe he could take a chance and try the thing. And I went there and Tommy was very nice. I wasn't experienced at really reading like the charts, because the first thing, like how to read a whole book with a major band, so I lasted about two or three weeks. But Tommy would always say, "Take another solo, kid" on the clarinet. He was very nice about it, he says, "Take another one, kid." He says, "That was nice." But as I say I think Charlie Shavers was on the band. So that was a nice experience, but I wasn't ready to read all those charts correctly on alto and do the clarinet solos. I needed more experience. And then I played a little bit with Boyd Raeburn. I guess those were some of the big bands before Louie Bellson, Buddy Rich.

MR: When you were doing the bar mitzvahs and the gigs to pay the rent, you were kind of expected to know a certain—

SM: Repertoire?

MR: Repertoire, right?

SM: Oh yeah. Well as I say you kind of grew up with all the standards and that was part of the thing other than if you had to play some ethnic Jewish stuff for the bar mitzvahs. Otherwise you know you just would hear the tunes on the radio. "I Hear a Rhapsody" or whatever that they might play at some of these gigs. Some of the tunes of the Latin stuff, "What a Difference a Day Made," and it became part of your repertoire, all the standards that you heard on the radio that were current at the time. That was before, what do you call it, "I Get No Satisfaction."

MR: You hinted at my next question, you know if any of the early rock & roll, if you began to get requests for that kind of thing on those gigs, and how did you deal with that?

SM: Actually I think I left before then or else it wasn't, maybe it was coming. I knew that was becoming more popular. I think other people were doing it or else I didn't get too much, especially on my instrument — maybe you had to do it more on guitar or something else.

MR: Oh yeah, okay. What prompted the move to the west coast?

SM: I think mostly there seemed to be maybe like a little slump in what was happening. Of course you know before that, before I went to the west coast I was with Buddy Rich, with the small group.

MR: Oh yeah, I wanted to ask you about that.

SM: For about two and a half years, we had Mike Mainieri and a few other people and Buddy. And that went very well. We just traveled around the world because he had a State

Department tour, we went to India and South America and Afghanistan and Vietnam, Nepal, just a lot of crazy places. And he had two records too, but they are kind of collector's items on different labels. But by the way, just to backtrack, I was at Manhattan School of Music for a while, and that's when I got the offer to go with Buddy. I think I went down to Birdland and someone said he's looking for somebody, Seldon Powell was leaving. And I think it was my friend again, Arnold Rosen, he said, "Why don't you get up there and play?" Anyhow I sat in with Buddy and he says, "You got the gig." Another time I remember going to Birdland and my friend also said, "Why don't you get up there and play with Lester Young?" So I got up to play and Lester Young tapped me on the back and said, "Go ahead, kid, blow." So that was nice of him. I remember another thing was Lester Young was walking across the street in New York and this is the famous Lester Young, he's walking across the street to the White Rose Bar and I'm crossing the street with him. And I said, "Tell me, could you tell me what you think about when you improvise?" So he said, "I just play from here." That was his answer. You know, just little things that you remember. And the other thing, I'm just going around to different things, just whatever comes to mind that I wanted to tell you. The other thing is when I was about 17, you know I was living in New York, so I went down to 52nd Street and they had all these great players there, Art Tatum, Bird, Erroll Garner. I walked into this, I was able to get in, maybe I looked a little older at the time or whatever, went in with somebody, but who was playing but Ben Webster was playing, and it was beautiful, smoky, and he was sounding so great, and I said that's what I want to do. So that's how that started, when I was about 17 I said wow, to be able to play the tenor that way. So that was a big influence.

MR: Really. That's a good story, kind of that romantic, semi-funky atmosphere.

SM: Yeah. The smoke is filling the air and he's playing, I don't remember what tune, but that sound and everything.

MR: The Ben Webster thing, yeah.

SM: Wow. That's what I wanted to do. I remember a few times we had different people sit in with us with Buddy's band, like Erroll Garner sat in and a lot of the drummers, Philly Joe Jones and Mel Lewis and Ed Shaughnessy, and I can't think of some of the other guys, Joe Morello. But Philly Joe sounded so good. But Buddy of course was, he'd wipe them all out with his things. I used to call him the Art Tatum of the drums, because you know he could just do anything, it was fantastic. You used to hear 20 minute drum solos practically every night for two years, and beautiful. He had such great control of everything.

MR: It must have been interesting to tour the whole world.

SM: That was interesting.

MR: Is there any place that you went to that really sticks out in your mind?

SM: Let me see. Well South America, that was great, like a thrill, especially when you're young and you see all these places, and I think maybe the carnival thing was going on but it just seemed so romantic and beautiful weather and women and everything. A great place. I think we were at the Copacabana like overlooking the beach. And the bossa nova was just kind of becoming popular and it was so beautiful. So that kind of sticks out. And I remember being in the tent with Buddy, in India, where they have these things to keep out the mosquitoes or whatever, and being in a tent with me and someone else over there. I guess he was getting stoned, and I had this little melodica and I was playing different things and everyone was breaking up and laughing. And I remember Buddy told me he says, "You have such great time," which was a nice little—

MR: Nice compliment from Buddy Rich.

SM: There's some other good stories that I remember, compliments that I just wanted to mention that I'm proud of like when I think of it. There's one, I was doing the "Soupy Sales Show" in Detroit. And I was walking down the street and I run into Bill Evans. And he says "I saw you on the 'Soupy Sales Show' I really dig your lines." Which was great.

MR: Isn't that interesting that he would pick that out, from Soupy Sales.

SM: Isn't that something? I guess it was in Detroit I guess and maybe he was in Detroit at the same time. No not Soupy Sales, Bill Evans told me.

MR: Yes I understand, right.

SM: The other thing, I was doing a scat thing. One of Stan Getz, he used to hang out with Morey Stein, so I did a thing and I was scat singing. Morey had died and there was a Alfonse's, it's a club. So afterwards Stan Getz told me he says, "Man you sound better than — you're one of the greatest scat singers." That's what he told me. You know so that was a nice compliment.

MR: When did the idea of singing through the flute start for you?

SM: There's a little story involved with that. I couldn't make a lot of noise in my apartment. I was living with my folks, and so I used to go in the closet and just [scats]. I'd sing while I was playing, because I wouldn't have to play the notes at full volume, something like that. People told me I used to practice on the subway, you know take out the flute and everything. I don't remember some of these crazy things you do when you're young.

MR: Yeah. People tell you you did though.

SM: I did, yeah. "Remember you used to take out the flute and play some bebop on the subway" or something. Because as I say I couldn't make a lot of noise, maybe it was late

at night and I wanted to play something so that's how that happened. Then I guess I recorded with it. And one of the earliest as far as I cam remember.

MR: Well Jake Hanna made up, he tells a story about you making this weird entrance—

SM: Oh yeah. He loves to tell that and no one could seem to tell it like him. We were playing at the Maryland Hotel in Chicago. And he builds up the story, he says, "And now, ladies and gentlemen, Buddy Rich, the world's greatest drummer." It's pitch black. And then he says, "And guess what happens" he says I'm late for the stage, and he says, "and here comes Sam running to get on the stage on time." "Now the world's greatest drummer." I knock over his cymbals and the whole bass drum and everything falls to the floor." The world's greatest drummer. And he fires me, and that's the story.

MR: Is there any truth to it?

SM: No. Maybe some, maybe I hit the cymbal or something or came in late.

MR: Gee, there should be some truth to it anyway, at least to elaborate on it, he's got to start somewhere.

SM: Yeah, there must be some truth but he exaggerates, but he tells it wonderfully.

MR: So the 60s were maybe kind of a difficult decade for jazz, at least in New York.

SM: Also, since my brother was out here, I guess my mother was encouraging me, well why don't you go try it out there, maybe there's an opportunity to get into pictures or be close to your brother, and it'll help you a little bit. So I did get out there. And then I did some T.V. shows out here, playing the studios, I did a few things with some of the studios. In fact he got me one of the earliest things, I'll tell you about the Frank Sinatra flute earlier. But I had a flute solo to do with Felix Slatkin or one of the early things with one of the studios. And I wasn't that experienced with orchestras, and I was a soloist. So what happens is if you kind of don't make the grade on a few of these things, they label you right away. He says, "Oh he's a great jazz player but he's not the studio guy." So I had a few opportunities when I wasn't ready, but then I did a few T.V. shows, "The Barbara McNair Show" or some other stuff, and so I remember Frank Strazzeri, we were talking about that once, something he said, he was not in the studios either. He said, "Well you didn't have your heart in it." Or some people like gear themselves up for that, they train you know, have classical training or this or that. And he'd joked, he said, "Bebop ruined my life." It was a joke, but what I meant was you know I had a few chances of doing that. So my brother was in the studios for about twenty years. But a few tests, and I think Patrick Williams, someone hired me, I got a call playing lead alto, like the alto solo behind a movie like [scats]. And I had to borrow an alto because I wasn't ready, I didn't have my own. Anyhow if you miss a few trials they label you, that's what I meant to say.

They say, “Oh he’s a great jazz player but he’s not really ready for this.” What I mean is you don’t get too many chances.

MR: Not too much forgiveness there.

SM: That’s what I meant. So I probably missed a few things.

MR: Well maybe it was fortunate because you ended up devoting more time to the jazz.

SM: Yeah, that’s always been my love is the jazz, always. I hear some people in the studios, you probably heard it already, saying, “Well tomorrow we’ve got M1 and M2 and M16,” you know the studio cues they call it. “Turn the page, M3” [scats]. Next cue. That’s their life — I mean not their life — their musical life is they don’t go out and play too much but they have this down where they’re technically able to play. Sometimes it’s maybe more involved but you know, so I did a little bit of that. And M 19, okay [scats]. Next. M 20. And how you make the money and so on and so on. But I’ve always had the most fun performing and playing and playing jazz.

MR: Can we listen to a little piece of something that I brought?

SM: Oh wow.

MR: Off —

SM: Oh I used to like that.

[audio interlude]

SM: Oh that sounds nice.

MR: It does sound nice, doesn’t it?

Boy, that holds up well I would say. Beautiful. In fact, the tune is “But Beautiful.” You know one thing I noticed about your playing is that you seem to really like to switch octaves frequently.

SM: You know I don’t think I focused on that other than just naturally. I didn’t focus on the fact that I’m switching octaves. Also I guess a sad story I guess in that I’m still involved with it, is someone cut the head off that flute, it’s like a French flute, like cut off the head joint, and so it’s never been the same but there was supposed to be a good repairman and he didn’t ask me about doing it, and I didn’t know you could fit other heads in it, but I sold the flute and had some other flutes. You know you get rid of some good instruments that were good and then say why did I get rid of that? Because they got such a beautiful recorded sound and you don’t have it now. In fact I used another flute that has certain things but it doesn’t have some other things like I had a Powell that I recorded on Xanadu and some of the early days I recorded on a Haynes. Now I have a Haynes with another head and I can’t afford the beautiful — like one day James Galway came in with two gold flutes. He let me and my brother play his flutes. And what I mean is he had the $22,000 platinum or gold flutes. It’s beautiful how you can get a beautiful tone. But in

fact I heard it was stolen later on, I don't know if he got them back or they sold his instruments, but what I mean a good instrument in the hands of a good player helps you play better. And I don't have the access to the best instruments. But anyhow I like — the sound was so good because I had another instrument, plus my playing.

MR: How did this come about? A wooden flute?

SM: Oh yeah, I wanted to tell you about that. I was with Red Norvo for a number of years. I went to Las Vegas, Tahoe. And so he used to go on the road with Frank Sinatra. In fact the record came out recently with Frank Sinatra with the Red Norvo group. So we were playing in Palm Springs and we went over to Frank's house. I played piano for Frank. He sang "Lady is a Tramp."

MR: At the house?

SM: At the house in Palm Springs. And he used to come into The Sands in Vegas and also the place Rimrocks in Palm Springs. He'd come in sometimes and just pass the group going into the lounge and say, "Hey Sam you're blowing your ass off" or something like that. Anyhow we were in Palm Springs and we played a little thing for him, and he came out with this thing and he said, "Sam, I want you to see something." So he came out with this box and I opened it and it's a flute, like a wooden flute made in Rudelcard, England, supposed to be hand made. And he said, "I know you'd appreciate it, it's yours." I flipped. You know Frank Sinatra giving me a beautiful flute. I couldn't sleep. I says wow, he gave me a flute, you know, Frank Sinatra. And so that's the flute in the picture. I was — Zan Stewart out here was doing an interview and he said, "We'll take a picture for the magazine." So that was the picture, and the guy who was taking the picture said well we'll just change your shirt and maybe you can use some of these pictures. That's what happened. Of course I hadn't had any pictures for a while other than the one of the cover, you know the Xanadu cover.

MR: What was it like to get record labels to record you? Has it been hard over the years?

SM: Well it was easy for me, I guess I was in my 20s, 22, 24, 22, 23, 24, just like the young lions today only maybe a little different. So I think with the help of my friend or I don't know how it came about but I got an offer to do the four albums for Bethlehem, but recently it's been very hard, from my conversations with other people, either you have to, even the bigger names like one you told me, Roger Kellaway, you have either putting up the money yourself or I'm not sure, but it's been harder recently to do it. I had one thing that I did with somebody, a home recording in a little place like this, I was in the other room and we did a thing where I was scat singing and they've been playing it out here a little bit, but the record isn't out yet, the CD isn't out yet. I could have brought that one but I didn't bring it yet. You showed me a good copy on this thing.

MR: Yeah. It sounds beautiful off of the LP you know?

SM: Yeah, wow. There's some student from Italy that came over here and he thought I was like Charlie Parker, "You're a genius" blah-blah-blah. Anyhow he wanted to get a copy of this *Catalyst* thing. And I have so much clutter in my place that I couldn't reach it, I don't know where it is. It's somewhere. But I have to send him a copy I think. The other thing is I did an album, I went to Japan with Ray Brown, Hank Jones and Alan Dawson. And we did a recording over there that is a CD. And he was supposed to send me a copy, because I don't have a copy of the CD, it's kind of hard to find but it's out there somewhere. I don't know why I mentioned that but just going around. Free association.

MR: Who were the other jazz players that you've listened to and enjoyed or not enjoyed?

SM: I listen to a lot of the people like Hubert Laws and Joe Farrell. In fact most of my influence has been more like saxophone players you see. So that's why I associate the bebop thing and the style plus my own whatever I do with those influences. So it seems like I listen to more saxophone players than flutists. I like a lot of these people. I was just more influenced by Charlie Parker and Stan Getz and Lee Konitz, that type of thing.

MR: You had some pretty nice compliments from — Charles Mingus called you the world's greatest jazz flute player.

SM: Yeah, well don't forget he put out that album—

MR: Yeah, well that helps, doesn't it.

SM: But he did like that. But he came into a club I was in in New York and as he came in he goes, "There's Sam Most, the world's greatest jazz flute player" whether he meant it or not. But it was nice. And also another one that called me his favorite bebop flutist was Charlie Mariano. I haven't seen him for a long time. And okay.

MR: You know, you asked Lester Young a question about what do you think about when you're improvising and he gave you that answer. What if I ask you the same question. Is it possible to put it into words?

SM: I don't know. I think it's hard for me to explain it myself. I try to get the emotional thing of course. I think it's a matter of all your experiences that come through too, but I think a lot of the things that you practice and everything comes into your improvisation, you know the technical thing. And sometimes it becomes maybe subconscious, the different exercises you practice, like [scats] so that goes with certain chords or certain scales and everything. And of course when you're playing you don't always think well I'm playing [scats] but from knowing these things and having it — just like classical training I guess — having this facility you are able to manipulate the chords or the harmonies instantaneously with some of these things that you have maybe under your fingers in your

mind. And so all that comes into play and sometimes some thinking of the chords while I'm playing say a standard.

MR: Sometimes you're thinking of the chords but not always?

SM: Not always, or else just the name of the chord see? I'm B flat now. And then automatically I think of melodies. I remember having an interview a long time — *Metronome*, *Down Beat*, saying like I like the lyrical quality. Like as if you are singing. Pretty melodies like [scats] something that makes sense and I always liked that. And that's what I sort of think about. So say if you know you're in B flat, then you know the intervals and what you can do. And you make up a melody right on the spot.

MR: Right.

SM: And that's more or less, I don't know if you can get any deeper in it, but that's the idea.

MR: Yeah. I know what you're saying.

SM: I know you know, yeah.

MR: It's a hard thing to put into words, and sometimes it just depends on the tune too. It seems like sometimes you have to think harder about the chords because of the particular changes in that song.

SM: Right, right. Other times it kind of flows naturally, like what is it, two, six, two one. I mean one, six, two, five or that type of thing. You just don't think about it because you hear it and then say I know this [scats] it's easy.

MR: Well can you still play "Cherokee" in twelve keys?

SM: I think I can yeah. Crazily enough.

MR: I can't play it in one, come on now.

SM: Oh yeah. I don't know for some reason you had to learn that because that was one of Charlie Parker's "Koko" you know, and it became a great exercise. In fact I used to do that even on piano because I play some piano, since I have been about 18. I didn't have a piano until I was 18 then a neighbor next door, I got a hold of one.

MR: Mostly self-taught on the piano?

SM: Mostly self-taught. A little study with some people, Hanon and different things, mostly self-taught and always interested in the harmonies.

MR: Yeah. it helps, definitely.

SM: It definitely helps like to — and it helps when you're playing with other people or yourself to go through tunes. I like the Aebersold things too. They're good. You know all the things, twelve keys there again. Yeah, yeah, "Cherokee" in twelve keys, but I was doing it years ago.

MR: Isn't that funny?

SM: Yeah.

MR: It comes around now that you can buy it to practice along with it.

SM: Right, right, right.

MR: Well there's so much available these days. What's going to happen with the wealth of jazz students? Do you think they'll have a place to practice their craft in the future?

SM: Yeah, I'm not sure whether there's going to be enough work although they say the cream will rise to the top if there's some outstanding musicians I guess somebody'll say this guy's too good like to — you know, you have to discover them.

MR: Yeah.

SM: I guess so but I don't know what's going to happen to all those people, either stage band people or people that play with the bands. I understand there's a lot of good people coming out, that some bands hire people from here and there, North Texas State or Berklee.

MR: Yeah. Well it's never been the most popular kind of music. Have you ever had occasion where people ask you to do something in the rock & roll vein?

SM: I've had to play a few gigs before. I was playing with one group that at first it was only ten percent rock & roll, then it came to be eighty percent rock & roll so I didn't stay with the band but you had to play certain things like they had these disco things or else the saxophone player had to play [scats]. I don't mean, I'm not singing it right but [scats] or certain, on the groove. And so I had to learn the phrases on the record like [scats], that type of thing. And I couldn't remember anything anyhow so all those things that you had to play rock & roll. So after a while I says I didn't fit in because I couldn't play the riffs that were on the record. I never wanted to memorize them. I was trying to memorize Charlie Parker solos.

MR: Not [scats].

SM: That's it. [scats]. Things like that.

MR: That's funny.

SM: So as I say when it became like eighty percent that, "I Get No Satisfaction" and I can't remember all the titles of the things like, you know I can't remember some of the tunes so then I didn't work with those groups.

MR: Let me ask you about a couple of people here that you've played for or with or they've played with you. Quincy Jones?

SM: Oh yeah. Quincy I actually did a recording for John Hammond on Vanguard and Quincy wrote one of the tunes, called "Funk Junction." That was before he became very popular as a writer.

MR: How about Chick Corea?

SM: Chick Corea, I just sat in with Chick when he was out here and went over to his house at a Valentine's Day party or something, and played a little bit.

MR: He's always liked jazz flute, hasn't he?

SM: Right. And of course we made that record with Joe Farrell, one of his flutists, but then he died.

MR: Yeah. That was a shame. I know you've recorded with, oh Sam Noto, look at that.

SM: Sam Noto is on one of the Xanadu albums, right? Have you heard some of these?

MR: Yes.

SM: Yeah. okay.

MR: Yes. And I met Sam, yeah.

SM: Oh, okay, so he was out here and we did a thing at Donte's, we did an album together with Sam, Sam Noto.

MR: Is there enough work in the Los Angeles area for a jazz musician that doesn't want to get into the studios these days?

SM: Not too well. You must heard the joke the Polish jazz musician that got into it for the money? Haven't you heard that joke?

MR: No I haven't.

SM: You haven't? Okay, so I told you.

MR: There you go. That just about sums it up. The Polish jazz musician—

SM: That got into jazz for the money. I thought you had heard that.

MR: No.

SM: Because it's pretty hard to, I don't know I guess some people have some outside things that they do but yeah I probably make it on little jazz gigs and casuals, and of course at my stage, Social Security and a little pension and the jazz gigs and the casuals. But of course there's not that much studio work around. Still hoping to get some more recordings some day. I don't know if I'll have to pay for them myself or what, or some small label, or what.

MR: When you get a gig in a jazz club, maybe a new one, do you have a circle of people that you call then?

SM: You know I don't have a mailing list. Many people—

MR: No but I mean to get the musicians to play with you.

SM: Oh you mean the musicians not the people?

MR: Yeah.

SM: Oh just people you know around town that do it — the guitar player or piano player. I used to work a lot with Frank Strazzeri and he was using Bill Perkins on some things. I don't get that many gigs as leader, occasionally, I just use some people that might be free

that you work with. I remember doing a gig when I had a little group, at some little restaurant, I had Ross Tompkins, Lawrence Marable, Jeff Hamilton. Pick-up groups. He's not available, get someone else. Some other thing with John Heard on bass or just some of the better people here that are around that are available.

MR: How has the L.A. scene changed since when you first moved out here?

SM: I just think mostly the studio scene is, for myself, not as plentiful. Very little, because of the synthesizers, one guy is doing all the work of maybe an orchestra or so on. So I don't know if it's changed so much except that fell off, the studio work and pictures and things like that. I seem to be working more at little jazz clubs or little gigs lately for some reason so that's good. My girlfriend says, "You must be playing good."

MR: That's good to hear.

SM: That's good to hear. So I keep trying to stay interested in music, at least do a little, say hello to the instruments every day.

MR: Say hello to the instruments every day.

SM: Or else they get mad you know. They say, "You haven't touched me for a few days, you think I'm going to play good?"

MR: You think I'm going to respond to you?

SM: You think I'm going to respond to you, yeah. And I spent a lot of time at the piano. Just like you do I like to look at either books or my own thing, either piano technique or mostly harmonies and what you could do with the chords. Same thing over again.

MR: Do you travel out from L.A. much these days?

SM: Not too much except the surrounding things like Palm Springs occasionally or just within a fifty mile radius or if I go out to Japan.

MR: Well I just have to listen to this one more time before I go.

SM: Oh thanks. I like that.

MR: Let's see if I can get this up here, because that is a nice way to wrap up.

[audio interlude]

SM: Oh that's pretty thanks. I still like to listen to these songs.

MR: Lovely.

SM: I have some things that I didn't tell you about.

MR: Go ahead.

SM: Oh, as I say I'm doing more scat singing now and also regular singing.

MR: Oh yeah? Like what do you like to sing?

SM: Oh well I like to sing, as I say my girlfriend would usually tell me I sound better when I sing up tunes, like happy tunes. Like I do "Lady Be Good" "Avalon" what are some of the other ones I do? Up tunes that I can scat on. "Indiana." I like to sing all the pretty

ballads like, oh the past few days, "My Funny Valentine" about four times. Once as a bossa nova or a ballad, so I like to sing the lyrics, it's nice. I may not be a Frank Sinatra or whatever it is, but it seems like I get some good response singing and also instrumentally, I'm getting some good response, and also I'm playing baritone lately, and that's why I brought some of the things. There's a few people here that you probably didn't interview, playing with Carl Saunders, a friend of mine. He is getting a few more albums out. He has like a benefactor that's putting in thousands, a doctor, that's nice it's always going to help.

MR: Oh yeah. Love those doctors, don't you?

SM: I had someone in 1985 that put out, I think it's listed here, that was kind of — Fernando Gelbart. He had some money and he says, I recorded with Frank Colette and he put the London Philharmonic Strings behind it. I didn't bring the album, so twenty strings behind me and Frank Colette, most all flute. But as I say he had some money, so let's do this. So I had four arrangers, George Calendrelli and some other people. But I haven't recorded since then, that was I think in 1985. I forgot where I'm wandering to. But so as I say Carl was saying, "Oh you sound so great on baritone, you ought to just don't play the other horns so much, just play baritone and flute. So occasionally I'll bring the baritone, just to have another voice.

MR: Yeah, you've got to think in a whole new key now too, right?

SM: Well I was playing alto so that's the alto key. So the alto, the tenor, the baritone, the piano, the flute the singing the scat — so that's my act lately.

MR: Get it covered.

SM: I've got it covered. In fact I played behind Madonna's brother I think, piano, recently on a gig, a trio.

MR: No kidding. What does Madonna's brother do?

SM: Well you know I'm not really sure except he hasn't announced it too much but someone told me, the guy that used to run Pasquale's out here, Pat Senatore, the bass player—

MR: No, but is he a singer or something?

SM: He sings, yeah. I don't know if it's professionally or what but he got a gig and I understand he says, "Oh that's Madonna's brother, Joey Ciccone."

MR: Oh yeah that last name rings a bell, that's right.

SM: Yeah so that might be him anyhow. I don't know whether he announces it. Anyhow I got a call to play piano with the bass player and the drummer, and it came out fairly good and people were really applauding for the piano. So I said hey this is nice. We had one of those, a nice keyboard a Roland RD 300. It sounded good with the amplification.

MR: So someone saw you that night, they think that you're a piano player.

SM: A few people.

MR: And the next time they'll see you and you'll just be playing flute.

SM: Hey this guy's versatile. I played in Cambria with Charlie Shumack, there's a club up there, so I was up there playing tenor with him and a few other people, I think my brother up there but he played vibes and I get on the piano for some things and the people were applauding when I played the solos, so I says hey I must be doing pretty good.

MR: All right.

SM: Anyhow this is my little thing. I don't know whether we missed anything but that's just a little idea of Sam Most and what is it, in 1999, really. I probably missed a few things but is there anything that you think might be interesting that I haven't touched on before we close it?

MR: Well have you done any private teaching? Do you pass on any of this to students?

SM: I do have two books out you know. I had one I think is out of print, *Jazz Flute Conceptions*, and the other one I got a lot of good response from some good musicians on *Metamorphosis*. It used to be *Metamorphosis*, written about the 1970s, and then Time Warner or Warner Publications, they changed the name to *Jazz Improvisation*. Unfortunately they left out the — they put a CD with it, like a play along, but they left out the information in the front, the information in the back, they just said, "People know that already" which I wish they hadn't done that. And I just have a few students here and there. I don't really have a place that I can teach so I just maybe sometimes teach at a store or that type of thing. I haven't give up yet, I'm still playing.

MR: Well I hope you don't.

SM: I hope to keep making each, each time you play like what do they say, you're as good as your last solo or something like that? So each time you play you keep trying to play some good music and so I played a gig the other day and my alto sounded good, the tenor sounded good, the alto flute, I've been playing alto flute lately because it has a nice warm sound on the flute, and my last gig was I had a lot of nice compliments. So you live compliment to compliment.

MR: Yeah. And you have a nice niche in jazz history I think. And I think that's nice.

SM: Oh that's nice, yeah. Yes that's my claim. I was one of the, they call me the father of jazz flute, or one of the early pioneers of jazz flute, and I'm still trying to hang in there and play some good music. I hope to re-record it again before the millennium. Boy that's almost another year, maybe the end of the millennium, whatever you call it.

MR: All right. Well I appreciate your making it tonight.

SM: It was a pleasure talking to you about the little things. I keep thinking I missed a lot of things, but you got a smattering of—

MR: An overview.

SM: An overview, yeah.

MR: And if we come back out maybe we'll pick up on the things that we missed the first time.

SM: Good, good, and say I don't know if you need this supplemental material but of course you can have this one and the picture.

MR: Great. Thank you.

SM: Thanks. It's been great. I hope maybe I'll get a copy too, huh?

MR: You will indeed.

SM: And I hope it came across okay.

MR: You did.

SM: Of course I understand you've done about 170 of these people, but that's just wonderful.

MR: That was fun, hey?

SM: That wasn't bad it was painless. You guys did wonderful. That was nice, you do a good interview.